

BHASKAR PAUL



Everyone sets out on a journey with a target. So did the team of Colors. CEO Rajesh Kamat and programming head Ashwini Yardi pinch themselves constantly for having become the number one Hindi general entertainment channel in just eight months. But this hasn't happened by fluke. Every member in the top management of Colors has brought something to the table. Kamat, 35, who comes from Endemol, has carried his love for all things big to the channel by launching the country's most extravagant reality show, *Fear Factor: Khatron Ke Khiladi*. Ironically, what Yardi, 36, treasures most about her stint as programming head of Zee TV is cost-cutting. "It's odd but somehow we work well," she says. She was very clear that regressive and fake dialogue would not find place. A product of two GECs, Star Plus and then Zee TV, Saurabh Tiwari, 32, creative head, fiction, at Colors, says that he has learnt that shows have to be either your story or your neighbour's story. "We absolutely don't accept created and forced drama," he adds.

THE COLORS TEAM

Rajesh Kamat, 35,
Ashwini Yardi, 36,
Saurabh Tiwari, 32

28

per cent is what Hindi general entertainment channels contribute to the total cable and satellite viewing in India

season with an average TRP of three. One week viewers tuned in to watch real-life married couple Arvind and Arati sort out their differences and another day they watched Bedi preside over a widowed and HIV-positive Sangeeta's battle with her mother-in-law. "The audience is very intelligent. You can't keep giving them the same thing," says Ajay Bhalwankar, programming head, Zee TV.

Stories have become weightier, peripheral expenses lighter. If more time was earlier spent on choosing plush carpets from Dubai for the sets, today

that energy is being channelled towards locating the right actor. Rupali Guha, producer, Film Farm, auditioned over 200 girls before she found Sparsh Khanchandani, the toothy protagonist of *Uttaran*. If a Balaji set costed a whopping Rs 3 to 4 crore, for art directors now, the focus is to be thrifty and real. Jayant Deshmukh, the set designer of shows like *Hum Ladkiyaan* on Sony, and *Yeh Rishta...*, says just like the stories have opened up, so have the windows of the previously closed sets. "Earlier the sets were gorgeous but they weren't

places people lived in," he says. If one episode of *Kyunki...* was made at a budget of Rs 40 lakh, an episode of *Bidaai* costs Rs 8 lakh. If a star like Smriti Irani was paid close to Rs 50,000 per episode, the leads of *Bidaai*, Parul Chauhan and Sara Khan, make not more than Rs 8,000 to Rs 10,000 per episode.

Prime time fatigue began sometime in 2006, when Zee TV put out *Saat Phere*, the story of an unattractive girl, Saloni, living in a society obsessed with fair skin. It challenged the rule of Star's bahu. The team at the helm of Zee TV then comprised